

• STUDENT SUPPORT & CULTURE · TEACHER-FACING

MORNING SPARK **TEACHER** GUIDE

The first thirty minutes of the day, run the same way in every room from kindergarten through eighth grade. This guide gives new and experienced teachers the exact timeline, words, recognition moments, and redirection moves so the arrival Do Now runs itself and the day starts calm.



• WHAT THIS IS

ONE ROUTINE, FOUR GRADE BANDS

Morning Spark is the Do Now students complete as they arrive, before Morning Meeting. It lives at the front of each grade band's Morning Meeting deck. Students walk in, see a task they can finish on their own in three to five minutes, record an answer, and move to IXL (grades 3–8) or read a book (grades K–2). After announcements, a two-minute reveal closes the task and hands off to Morning Meeting, or to the Friday Cypher.

5

fixed formats, one per weekday

4

grade-band decks: K–1, 2–3, 4–5, 6–8

2 min

maximum for the reveal

DAY	FORMAT	WHAT STUDENTS DO
Monday	Check-In	Name how they are arriving, privately, on a folded slip.
Tuesday	Picture of the Day	Notice, wonder, or make a claim about one image.
Wednesday	Zoom In	Guess what a close-up shows and name the clue.
Thursday	Would You Rather	Pick a side and give a reason.

Friday

Wonder

Predict the answer to a real science question.

Every band uses the same weekly theme and the same format each day. What changes is the depth of thinking. A kindergartner guesses what the sunflower is; an eighth grader reads a tree's age from its rings. Because the formats line up, any student can be moved to an easier or harder band's version on the same day.

WHY IT WORKS

Predictability lowers the stress of walking in. A task that needs no explanation frees the teacher to greet every student by name at the door. The reveal gives the task a reason to exist, so students take it seriously. Consistency across rooms means a student who changes classes, or a substitute who covers one, already knows the routine.

1. The morning timeline
2. Before the first morning
3. Running the 30 minutes
4. Equity sticks and cold call
5. Turn and talk
6. LiveSchool moments
7. Day-by-day cards
8. When behavior gets in the way
9. Scaffolding across bands
10. Building student investment
11. Tech troubleshooting
12. Pocket card

● THE MORNING TIMELINE

FIVE PHASES, ONE CLOCK

TIME	PHASE	TEACHER IS	STUDENTS ARE
7:10	Set	Opening the deck, turning on Repeat aloud, placing paper and pencils.	Not yet in the room.
7:15	Arrive	At the door, greeting each student by name, pointing to the screen.	Entering at voice 0–1, starting the Do Now.
7:15–7:37	Work	Circulating once the door slows: narrating, supporting, awarding LiveSchool points for sustained work.	Finishing the Do Now, then working in IXL.
~7:37	Stop	Giving the silent hand raise. Announcements are the hard stop.	Pencils down, eyes up, voice 0.

After announcements	Reveal	Running the reveal slide: think time, equity stick, turn and talk. Two minutes, no more.	Answering, voting, talking with a partner.
7:45	Hand off	Advancing to the Morning Meeting slide (Monday to Thursday) or the Friday Cypher slide.	Putting materials away and moving to the circle.

TWO RULES THAT PROTECT THE TIMELINE

Announcements always end the work period. Whatever students are doing, they stop. Nobody finishes a sentence first.

If announcements run long, the reveal shrinks, not Morning Meeting. Cut to one cold call, skip the turn and talk, and start Morning Meeting on time. On a very long announcement day, skip the reveal entirely and open Morning Meeting with the answer.

Late arrivals. There is no cutoff. A student who arrives late works on the Do Now until announcements start, then stops with everyone else. Every reveal is built so a student who did not finish, or never saw the Do Now, can still take part.

Friday. Friday Cypher starts at 7:45, the same time Morning Meeting starts on other days. Friday is the schoolwide community celebration, so there is no classroom Morning Meeting. After the reveal, the deck shows "Time for Friday Cypher." Students report to the hallway once the announcement is made.

● BEFORE THE FIRST MORNING

SETUP CHECKLIST

Complete this once before launch and again after any long break. Everything on it prevents a problem that otherwise shows up at 7:16 with twenty students in the room.

TECHNOLOGY

- ☐ Download the grade band's deck file and open it in Chrome on the projector computer. Preview windows can block the read-aloud voice, so project from the downloaded file.
- ☐ Press the EN and ES buttons on any slide to confirm the computer plays both voices. If there is no sound, check the computer's volume and that the file is open in Chrome.
- ☐ Find the control bar. It appears at the bottom when the mouse moves and hides after a few seconds. Keys 1 to 5 jump to Monday through Friday; the arrow keys move through a day's three slides.
- ☐ Grades 3–8: confirm students can log in to IXL on their own. A student who cannot log in has nothing to do after the Do Now, and that is where arrival problems start. The top-right corner of each Do Now slide shows today's Math and Reading IXL codes for each grade in the band. Students

type the code into IXL. The codes come from the school's IXL code list and change each day on their own.

- ☐ Grades K–2 do not go to IXL. Students who finish read a book, so keep a book bin at every table. In the 2–3 deck, grade 3 goes to IXL and grade 2 reads.

PAPER

- ☐ Print the band's student pages. Page 1 holds four Monday check-in slips per sheet; cut them in advance. Page 2 is the weekly page students use Tuesday to Friday (the Do Now Log in grades 6–8).
- ☐ Choose one fixed spot for weekly pages, such as a folder on each desk or a bin by the door. Students should never need to ask where their paper is.
- ☐ Set out a closed box or envelope for Monday check-in slips. The counselor picks up the slips by 10:00 a.m. every Monday.

PARTICIPATION TOOLS

- ☐ Make one equity stick per student with the student's name. Keep two cups: one labeled for sticks not yet called, one for sticks already called.
- ☐ Assign standing turn-and-talk partners (Partner A and Partner B) and post the pairs. Pair emerging English speakers with a patient partner, and with a same-language partner when possible.
- ☐ Open LiveSchool on a phone or tablet so points can be awarded while circulating, not from the desk later.

TEACH IT ONCE

Before the first real morning, run the routine as a practice with students: enter, find the Do Now, answer, move to IXL, hear the stop signal, do a reveal. Practice takes ten minutes and saves weeks of reminders. The same practice is the reteach when the routine slips.

● RUNNING THE 30 MINUTES

WHAT TO SAY, WHEN TO SAY IT

AT THE DOOR (7:15 ONWARD)

Stand at the threshold where both the hallway and the room are visible. Greet each student by name, then point to the screen. Keep the door exchange short so the line keeps moving.

"Good morning, Aaliyah. Glad you're here. Spark is on the screen."

"Morning, Mateo. Do Now first, then IXL."

Use the same two-part direction every day so it becomes automatic. In K-2, say "Do Now first, then read a book."

"Buenos días, Hana. La tarea está en la pantalla. Primero la tarea, luego IXL."

For students more comfortable in Spanish. The deck also reads every prompt aloud in both languages.

If a student arrives upset, do not process it at the door. Acknowledge, give a place to land, and follow up once the room is working.

"You look like the morning was rough. Take your seat, take a breath. I'll come to you in two minutes."

TURN ON REPEAT ALOUD

With Repeat aloud on, the deck reads the Do Now in English and then Spanish every 90 seconds. A student who walks in at 7:28 hears the directions without the teacher leaving the door. It turns off by itself on reveal slides.

CIRCULATING (ONCE ARRIVALS SLOW)

Walk a loop that passes every table. The job is to keep work going, not to check answers. Three moves in order:

1. **Narrate what is working**, quietly and specifically, to students near someone who has not started.
"Jaylen already has his claim written. Fatima found two pieces of evidence."
2. **Unstick one student** with a frame, not an explanation. Point to the sentence frame on the screen or offer a starting choice.
3. **Award LiveSchool points for sustained work**, two to three minutes into a student's Do Now, never for the first move. See the LiveSchool section for exact wording.

"Start with the frame on the screen: I think it is ___ because ___. Fill in the first blank."

"You can draw it first or write it first. Your call."

"That's one reason. Can you add a second one before IXL?"

For a student who finishes in thirty seconds with a thin answer.

THE STOP (ANNOUNCEMENTS)

Use the schoolwide silent hand raise. Wait for the class to echo it before announcements begin.

"Hands up, voice 0. Pencils down, eyes on the speaker."

THE REVEAL (AFTER ANNOUNCEMENTS)

Advance one slide. The reveal follows the same four beats every day.

1. **Show:** the answer, zoom-out, vote, or explanation on screen.
2. **Think:** ten seconds of silent think time. Everyone has an answer before anyone speaks.
3. **Call:** one or two equity sticks.
4. **Talk:** a 30-second turn and talk, only if time allows.

THE HAND OFF (7:45)

Advance to the Morning Meeting slide. On Fridays, advance to the Friday Cypher slide; students report to the hallway once the announcement is made.

"IXL closed, materials in the folder. Walk to the circle and find your spot."

● EQUITY STICKS AND COLD CALL

EVERYONE THINKS, ANYONE CAN BE CALLED

Equity sticks, also called cold call sticks, make participation fair and predictable. Every student prepares an answer because any stick can come up, and the same few voices stop carrying the room. Used well, cold call is an invitation, not a trap.

HOW TO RUN IT

1. Ask the question first, then give think time. Pulling the stick before the question tells everyone else they can stop thinking.
2. Pull a stick from the "not yet called" cup. Say the name warmly and repeat the question.
3. Accept the answer, name what was strong in it, and move the stick to the "called" cup.
4. Refill the first cup when it runs low, so every student is called before anyone is called twice.

"Ten seconds to think. Everyone has an answer. ... Kofi, what season do you think it is, and what's your evidence?"

WHEN A STUDENT IS STUCK

The student still participates. Lower the demand without letting the student opt out.

"Want to use the frame? It starts, I think it is ____."

"Would you like to hear one idea from a friend first? I'll come right back to you."

Then actually return to that student. The return is what keeps this safe and accountable.

"Point to the picture you chose."

For K–1 students and newcomers, a pointed answer is a full answer.

GUARDRAILS

- **Never cold call on the Monday check-in.** Feelings are private. Monday's reveal uses volunteers only.
- Do not use a stick to catch a student who is off task. That turns the tool into a consequence and students stop trusting it.
- For students with IEP or 504 accommodations around verbal response, honor the accommodation. A written or pointed response counts.
- Praise the thinking, not the correctness. Wrong guesses on Zoom In and Wonder days are the point.

● **TURN AND TALK**

THIRTY SECONDS, EVERY VOICE

A turn and talk gets every student speaking in the time it takes one student to share. Keep it short and structured.

1. **Set the stem:** read the sentence frame from the slide.
2. **Name who starts:** "Partner A first." This removes the negotiation.
3. **Voice 2, 30 seconds each:** say "Switch" at the halfway point.
4. **Listen in:** stand near two pairs. Choose one strong idea to share with the class.
5. **Call back:** silent hand raise, then one pair shares what the partner said.

"Turn to your partner. Partner A first. Use the frame: I would choose ___ because ___. Thirty seconds, voice 2. Go."

"Switch. Partner B."

"Hands up. Marisol, tell us what your partner said."

Sharing the partner's idea builds listening and gives shy students a safer way to speak.

In K–1, turn and talk is knee to knee and ten to fifteen seconds. Model it once with a student before asking pairs to try it.

RECOGNITION THAT NAMES THE BEHAVIOR

LiveSchool points are Cardinal Cash. Every award names a specific behavior tied to Safe, Respectful, or Responsible, and is read aloud to the student when given. Points go to sustained evidence during the routine, not after it and not for the first move.

NEVER AWARD POINTS FOR

being quiet, simply sitting down, complying with a basic expectation, or getting an answer correct. And never deduct points for Level 1 slips at arrival; deductions are only the logging of Level 3 and above events, never a threat.

APPROVED MORNING SPARK MOMENTS

VALUE	BEHAVIOR (LIVESCHOOL CATEGORY)	WHEN IT HAPPENS IN MORNING SPARK
Responsible	Held a routine when it slipped	A student got off track, then restarted the Do Now without a second reminder.
Responsible	Followed through on a commitment	Finished the Do Now all the way through and moved to IXL independently.
Respectful	Used a voice frame	Used the sentence frame in a cold call or turn and talk.
Respectful	Listened through a disagreement	Thursday: heard a partner's opposite choice and repeated it back fairly.
Respectful	Welcomed a new or younger student	Showed a late or new student where the Do Now and paper are.
Safe	Used a regulation strategy	Arrived upset and used a breath, water, or a calm spot, then rejoined.
Safe	Helped a peer reset	Quietly helped a classmate who was frustrated get started.

SAY IT OUT LOUD, THEN TAP

LIVESCHOOL · RESPONSIBLE "Nia, you stuck with the Do Now all the way to IXL. Followed through."

LIVESCHOOL · RESPONSIBLE "Dante, you got pulled off, then came right back to your claim on your own. That's holding the routine."

LIVESCHOOL · RESPECTFUL "Zaid used the frame word for word: I think it is late summer because. Voice frame."

LIVESCHOOL · RESPECTFUL "Amara showed Hana where the check-in box is. Welcomed a classmate."

LIVESCHOOL · SAFE "Jaylen, you came in heavy and took a minute to breathe before you started. That's a regulation strategy."

KEEP IT FAIR

Aim for points to different students each morning. A quick way is to glance at the equity sticks in the "called" cup and look for evidence from students who have not been recognized this week. LiveSchool reports feed the monthly equity audit, and patterns of who is and is not recognized show up there.

WHAT EACH MORNING NEEDS

Each card lists the teacher's job for that day, the cold-call question and turn-and-talk stem for every band, and one thing to watch for. Questions match what is on each band's reveal slide.



MONDAY · CHECK-IN

Private by design

Do Now: Students circle how they feel (K–3 faces; 4–8 energy scale and feeling words) on a slip, fold it, and put it in the box. The slip includes an option to talk to an adult.

Reveal: A breathing strategy done together: balloon breaths (K–3), box breathing (4–5), or the double sigh (6–8). Volunteers only; no equity sticks.

"Every feeling is welcome here. We're going to breathe together three times. Follow the slide."

Teacher job: Close the box before Morning Meeting. The counselor picks up the slips by 10:00 a.m. Anyone who asked to talk to an adult is seen that same day. A slip that raises a safety concern is handled under campus reporting procedures the same day. Students are never told their slip is secret, because some concerns must be shared with the right staff.

Watch for: any comment on an individual answer in front of the class. Check-in answers are never discussed publicly.

LIVESCHOOL · SAFE "Lucia, you used the breath and your shoulders came down. That's a regulation strategy."



TUESDAY - PICTURE OF THE DAY

A community garden on a city block

BAND	COLD-CALL QUESTION (AFTER THINK TIME)	TURN-AND-TALK STEM
K-1	What do you see? Point and tell.	I see ____.
2-3	What do you notice? What do you wonder?	I notice _____. I wonder _____.
4-5	What season is it? What's your evidence?	I think it is ____ because I see _____.
6-8	Why would neighbors turn an empty lot into a garden?	I think they built it because _____. My evidence is _____.

Reveal move: Count the tomatoes together (K-3). In 4-8, ask for a second piece of evidence from a new stick.

Watch for: deficit framing. The picture shows neighbors who built something. Keep the conversation on what the community made, not what it lacks.



WEDNESDAY - ZOOM IN

Sunflower (K-5) · Tree rings (6-8)

BAND	COLD-CALL QUESTION (AFTER THINK TIME)	TURN-AND-TALK STEM
K-1	What do you think it is?	I think it is a _____.
2-3	What's your guess, and what clue did you use?	I think it is ____ because I see _____.
4-5	How are the seeds arranged, and why?	The seeds are ____ so that _____.
6-8	What is it? Why are some rings thin?	It is _____. Thin rings mean _____.

Reveal move: The slide zooms out on its own. Press "Zoom again" to replay it. Pause before the zoom finishes and ask for one more guess.

Watch for: treating wrong guesses as mistakes. Every guess that uses a clue is good thinking. Say so.



THURSDAY - WOULD YOU RATHER

Pick a side, give a reason

BAND	COLD-CALL QUESTION (AFTER THINK TIME)	TURN-AND-TALK STEM
K-1	Bird or bee? Why?	I would be a ____.
2-3	Bird or bee? What's your reason?	I would be a ____ because ____.
4-5	Wind or bird: which seed trip is riskier?	I would travel by ____ because ____.
6-8	Garden or court? Now argue the other side.	Someone might choose ____ because ____.

Reveal move: Students raise hands for each side while the teacher taps +1 on the slide to build the live vote. Then one stick from each side.

LIVESCHOOL - RESPECTFUL "Yusuf, you chose the court and still explained the garden side fairly. Listened through a disagreement."

Watch for: the vote becoming a competition. Both answers are right. The point is the reason.



FRIDAY - WONDER

Why do leaves change color?

BAND	COLD-CALL QUESTION (AFTER THINK TIME)	TURN-AND-TALK STEM
K-1	Is it the sun, the cold, or paint?	I think it is ____.
2-3	Why do you think leaves change?	I think leaves change because ____.
4-5	Was your prediction close? What would you change?	I predicted _____. Now I know _____.
6-8	Did your hypothesis hold up? Revise it with one fact.	My revised hypothesis is ____ because ____.

Reveal move: Three panels appear in order. Read each one, then call one stick after panel 3.

Then: Advance to "Time for Friday Cypher." Cypher starts at 7:45. Students report to the hallway once the announcement is made.

THE LEAST MOVE THAT WORKS

Most arrival behavior is Level 1 on the campus Student Behavior Levels chart: off task, calling out, side conversations, a slow start, or a minor refusal. Level 1 is handled in the room with the smallest move that works. Start at step 1 and move up only if the step before did not work. Correct the routine, not the child.

1 PROXIMITY AND A POINT

Walk to the student and point to the screen or the paper. No words. Most slow starts end here.

2 NARRATE NEARBY

Quietly name what a student close by is doing well, focused on the work. "Kofi's already on his second sentence."

3 PRIVATE REDIRECT

Get close and quiet, name the next step, and walk away. Walking away signals trust.

"Do Now first. Step one is the frame on the screen. I'll check back."

4 OFFER A CHOICE

Two acceptable options return control to the student.

"You can start at your desk or at the back table. Which one?"

5 RETEACH THE ROUTINE

If several students are off, the routine has slipped, not the students. Stop, re-cue, and practice entry for sixty seconds. Reteach is the consequence.

"Let's reset. Voice 1, eyes on the Do Now, pencils moving. We'll practice that for one minute."

6

BEYOND LEVEL 1

If behavior escalates or is unsafe, follow the Student Behavior Levels chart. A tap-in follows the Tap-In Conversation Guide and Script Bank. Patterns over time go on an MTSS Behavior Request with the Tier 1 supports already tried.

COMMON ARRIVAL MOMENTS

SITUATION	SAY OR DO
Head down, will not start	Crouch to eye level. "Hey. I'm right here. You can get water and come back, or sit up and just look at the picture for a minute. Which one?"
"I don't know what to write"	"That's okay. Start with the frame, or draw what you see first."
Two students talking at voice 3	Walk over, hold up one finger. "Voice 1." Move on.
Done in 30 seconds	"Strong start. Add one more reason, then IXL." Or hand over the next band's prompt.
Wandering instead of IXL	"Do Now is finished? Show me, then IXL. Or I can help you log in."
Arrives upset from the hallway	Do not process at the door. "Take your seat and breathe. I'll come to you in two minutes." Then follow up.

Something on a slip worries you Follow campus reporting procedures the same day. Do not promise the student secrecy.

AVOID

- Correcting from across the room. An audience makes students defend themselves.
- Arguing at the door. The line behind the student is waiting.
- LiveSchool deductions or point threats for Level 1 behavior.
- Holding a student out of the reveal or Morning Meeting to finish the Do Now.

• SCAFFOLDING ACROSS BANDS

SAME DAY, SAME PICTURE, RIGHT-SIZED TASK

Because all four bands run the same format on the same day, a student can use another band's page and still take part in the class reveal. On Wednesday, grades 6–8 use a different picture. This is a support, not a label, and it can change week to week.

STUDENT	MOVE	EXAMPLE
Needs reading support	Use one band lower	A 4th grader uses the 2–3 page: same garden, a sentence frame instead of a claim with two pieces of evidence.
New to English	Picture page plus audio	Use the K–1 or 2–3 page and the ES read-aloud button. A pointed or drawn answer counts.
Ready for more	Use one band higher	A 5th grader who finishes early answers the 6–8 challenge question for the day.
Needs time	Shorten, don't skip	Complete only the first line or the choice. Partial work on time beats full work that eats IXL.
Has IEP or 504 supports	Apply the plan	Accommodations such as read-aloud, extended time, or alternative responses apply to Morning Spark like any task.

Keep a few copies of the neighboring bands' weekly pages in the room so the switch takes no time.

Other home languages. The decks read every prompt aloud in English and Spanish. Some students speak Haitian Creole and other home languages. For these students, seat a same-language peer nearby

when possible and make that peer the turn-and-talk partner, use the picture-based K–1 or 2–3 page, and accept a pointed, circled, or drawn answer as a full answer.

● BUILDING STUDENT INVESTMENT

MAKE THE REVEAL WORTH WAITING FOR

- **Always reveal.** A Do Now that is never closed teaches students it does not matter. Even on a rushed day, show the answer.
- **Give students jobs.** A rotating Spark Captain presses the read-aloud button, taps the vote buttons, or reads the reveal aloud. In grades 3–8, the captain can pull the equity stick.
- **Quote students back.** Repeat a strong student answer word for word during the reveal, with the student's name. Being quoted is powerful recognition.
- **Connect the days.** Point out the threads: the cardinal on Tuesday's roof is Thursday's bird; in grades K–5, Tuesday's garden holds Wednesday's sunflower.
- **Carry it to Friday.** Save the week's best "because" for a Cypher shout-out.
- **Peer recognition.** In grades 3–5, students nominate a peer's strong reason. In grades 6–8, peer recognition in LiveSchool is the main voice.

● TECH TROUBLESHOOTING

QUICK FIXES

PROBLEM	FIX
No read-aloud sound	Open the downloaded file in Chrome, not in a preview window. Check the computer's volume.
Wrong day showing	Press 1 to 5 for Monday to Friday, or move the mouse and use the day buttons.
Controls disappeared	Move the mouse or tap the screen. The bar hides itself after a few seconds.
Want to preview the whole week	Press "Week view" in the control bar. On a phone, the deck opens in Week view automatically.
Vote count needs a restart	Press "Clear votes" in the corner of Thursday's reveal.

THE 30 MINUTES ON ONE PAGE

MORNING SPARK - EVERY DAY

7:10	Deck open in Chrome. Repeat aloud on. Paper out. LiveSchool open.
7:15	At the door. Name plus "Do Now first, then IXL." Point to the screen.
Work	Loop the room: narrate, unstick with the frame, award points for sustained work.
~7:37	Silent hand raise. Announcements are the hard stop.
Reveal	Show, think 10 seconds, pull a stick, turn and talk if time. Two minutes.
7:45	Morning Meeting slide. Friday: Cypher slide, then the hallway on the announcement.

LEAST MOVE THAT WORKS

1-2	Proximity and point. Narrate nearby.
3-4	Private redirect. Offer two choices.
5	Many students off? Reteach the entry for 60 seconds.
6	Beyond Level 1: Behavior Levels chart, tap-in, MTSS Behavior Request.

LIVESCHOOL

Say it	Name, behavior, value: "Mateo, you started right away. That's responsible." Then tap.
Never	For quiet, sitting, compliance, or correct answers. No deductions for Level 1.

NEVER ON MONDAY

Check-In

No cold call. No public comment on answers. Counselor picks up slips by 10:00 a.m.

EVERY MORNING, **THE SAME START.**

Student Support & School Culture · Matchbook Learning, Wendell Phillips School 63
M. Williams, Director of Student Support & School Culture

SAFE. RESPECTFUL. RESPONSIBLE.